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Léa

September 1942

“I’ve written a letter of recommendation,” Maître Mallon said, shadowy rings like half-moons under his eyes rising through the lenses of his glasses. He lifted a paper from the desk drawer. “It should help you get a new position.”

“Thank you,” Léa said, reaching for the letter. Though under enormous pressure himself, she knew he’d done all he could to keep her. At eighteen, she’d started as an intern typist at Mallon Notary, and though her dismissal was expected, it still hit with unexpected force. An autumn wind blew through the open window, riffling the papers on his desk. She got up and put them back in order.

Maître Mallon waved his hand, signaling her to stop.

Léa felt a tightening behind her eyes and turned away. Knowing this was hard on him, she didn’t want to make it any worse. She glanced at the wooden desk in the corner where she’d spent long hours hunched over a pale gray Hermes typewriter, the four rows of white letters on black keys imprinted in her mind.

“Maître Dupont has plenty of business. Go see him with my letter. He will take you on.”

She turned back, shaking her head. “How can I?”

He removed his glasses and rubbed his eyes. “I’ve done you a disservice.”

“I’m glad I know.”

Even if he hadn’t told her about the camps, she would have figured it out after typing his response to the Parisian notary. Maître Mallon had been